

THE WORDS THEY USE

A plain list of what the words in your letters mean. Alberta disability supports for children and adults · The Alberta Disability System Breakdown · September 2026

Nobody explains these to you. They turn up in a letter or a form and you are supposed to already know. Here is what they mean.

If a word here does not match what your worker told you, ask them which rule they are using. You are allowed to ask that.

THE TWO PROGRAMS

FSCD stands for Family Support for Children with Disabilities. It is for children under 18.

PDD stands for Persons with Developmental Disabilities. It is for adults 18 and over. You can apply at 16, but the help does not start until 18.

AISH is money to live on for adults with a severe disability. It is a different thing again. A person can be on PDD and AISH at the same time.

ADAP is the Alberta Disability Assistance Program. It is the other adult money program.

WHAT FSCD CALLS ITS HELP

FSCD has two kinds of help. This matters, because they have different rules and different amounts.

Family support services. Help for you, the parent. To get it you need a diagnosis saying your child has a disability. That is the only test.

Child-focused services. Help aimed at your child. To get it you need that same diagnosis and one more thing. You need an assessment saying the disability makes ordinary daily life much harder for her. That second step is the whole difference.

Respite. Someone else looks after your child so you get a break. Respite is on both lists. They are separate amounts and one does not use up the other.

- Family support respite: up to **240 hours a year**.
- Child-focused respite: short hourly care, up to **30 whole days a year**, and more days again if they are needed to keep your home as your child's main home.

Homemaker services. Help with house cleaning and laundry when your child's care needs get in the way. Up to **12 hours a month**.

In-home care. Care for your child at home, care for brothers and sisters, and help with daily household tasks. Up to **50 hours a week**. It is for children with complex needs, and only when the director thinks it is the best way.

Personal care aide. Someone to help with washing, dressing, toileting and other daily personal care. Up to **4 hours a day**.

Community aide. Someone to help your child take part in activities in the community. Up to **144 hours a year**.

Behavioural aide. Someone to help with your child's behaviour, and to help you manage it. Up to **10 hours a week for 6 months**. It can run longer if a review says more is needed.

Child care costs. If you are at work, school or training, FSCD may cover the extra child care cost caused by the disability. Under 13, it covers the extra above normal child care. Age 13 and over, it covers the cost caused by the disability.

Specialized services. The most fought-over kind. Your child has to have significant needs in **two or more** of these five: behaviour; communication and getting on with others; thinking and learning; physical and motor development; self-help and coping skills. On top of that there are more conditions, including a team of different professionals assessing her and recommending it.

And there is a catch worth knowing. Specialized services cannot be given to help with education or schoolwork. That is written into the rules.

WHAT PDD CALLS ITS HELP

Home living supports. Help to live as independently as possible.

Community access supports. Help to take part in things.

Employment supports. Help to find and keep a paid job.

Specialized community supports. Help from experts for extra needs, such as mental health or behaviour.

Respite. A break for the people you live with who care for you.

Family Managed Services (FMS). You or a family member runs the services instead of an agency. The person who signs is called the **FMS Administrator**. They are **not paid** for that job. They hire and pay staff, follow employment law, keep records for seven years, and pay for things first and claim the money back afterwards.

Assessment of Needs. PDD's process for working out what you need. The manual says it is **not** a medical assessment.

Service plan. The document saying what PDD will provide and how much.

Critical and urgent needs. Words PDD uses to decide whether you get a service plan at all. **Nobody has written down what they mean.** They are in the policy manual twice, and are defined nowhere — not in the manual, not in the law.

THE PEOPLE AND THE OFFICES

Guardian. In the law, this means the parent or the person legally responsible for the child. If you are the parent, the law is talking about you.

Director. The government official who makes the decision. Your caseworker usually acts for the director. Some things, like an appeal, must go to the director personally.

Caseworker. The person you deal with day to day. They usually act for the director rather than being the director.

Disability Services office. The local office holding your file.

Appeals Secretariat. A separate office that handles appeals. Not part of FSCD or PDD.

Appeal panel (PDD) or appeal committee (FSCD). The independent group who hear an appeal. PDD's is also called the **Citizen's Appeal Panel**, a name that appears in no law.

Multi-disciplinary team. Several professionals of different kinds — for example a doctor, a therapist and a psychologist — who assess your child together.

Ombudsman. An independent office that investigates unfair government process. They look at how a decision was made, not whether it was the right decision.

WHEN YOU DISAGREE

There are three ways to push back and they are not the same.

Concern resolution. Talking to the caseworker, then their manager. No form, no deadline, no clock.

Review. Managers who did not make the first decision look at it again. **30 days to ask.** Free.

A review does not stop your appeal clock. The FSCD manual says so outright. Only mediation stops it.

Mediation. A neutral outsider helps you and the program reach an agreement. **30 days to ask.** The mediator does not decide anything.

Mediation stops the clock. In FSCD the appeal deadline pauses while mediation runs, then picks up where it left off. In PDD it swaps to 30 days from the day mediation ends.

Careful with PDD mediation: unless you agree otherwise, you and the program **split the mediator's costs**. Ask what that will be, in writing, first.

Appeal. An independent group reviews the decision. **45 days**, and this one is in the law.

Notice of Decision. The letter telling you what was decided. It should give the decision, the reasons, the date, and how to push back. **If you only got a phone call, ask for the letter.** Your 45 days runs from the written notice.

Suspended. Means the clock stops for a while, then starts again where it stopped. It does not start over.

Served on the director. Means delivered to the director in person or by post or email, not just mentioned to your caseworker. FSCD appeals have to be served on the director.

Judicial review. Asking a court to look at how a government decision was made. You would want a lawyer.

MONEY WORDS

Line 23600. A line on your tax return, near the bottom of page 4. It is labelled net income. FSCD uses it to work out what you pay before they help.

The 2% amount. For medical costs, you pay the first slice yourself. That slice is 2% of both parents' line 23600 added together. FSCD may help with costs above it.

Reimbursement. You pay first, then claim the money back.

Rate. What the program pays per hour. For most services, **the rate is not published anywhere**. Not in the law, not in the manual.

Schedule A and Schedule B. Parts at the back of a service contract. Schedule A lists the services. Schedule B is the invoice layout. The rate itself is set in a separate document called a Referral Confirmation, which you will not normally see.

Balance billing or top-up. When a provider charges you the gap between what they charge and what the program pays. Nothing in the FSCD rules allows this, and nothing forbids it. Ask any provider in writing, before you start, whether any amount will come to you.

THE WORDS IN THE LAW

Knowing which of these you are being told matters, because they do not carry the same weight.

Act. A law passed by the Legislature. The strongest.

Regulation. Detailed rules made under an Act. Still law. Written by government, not voted on.

Policy manual. The program's own instructions to its staff. **Not law.** It can be changed by the department without telling anyone.

Guidance page. A page on alberta.ca. The weakest, and often the only version a family is shown.

So when someone says "that's the policy", ask whether it is in the Act, in the regulation, or only in the manual. It is a fair question and the answer matters.

Section. A numbered part of a law. Written like s.7 or section 4(1)(k).

Schedule. An attachment at the end of a law, often a form.

Repealed. Cancelled. It no longer applies.

Current as of. The date the version you are reading was last updated. Anything after that date is not in it.

Expires. Some regulations have an end date built in. The FSCD one ends **30 June 2029**. The PDD one ends **30 September 2029**.

FORMS AND FILES

Why government forms will not open on your phone. Many Alberta and federal forms are built in an old format called **XFA**. Phones, tablets and web browsers cannot open them. You get a page saying to use Adobe Reader on a computer. This affects **26** of the forms on this site, including every appeal form.

Watch out: on some forms the file marked **FILLABLE** is the one that will not open, and the plain one will. Try the plain one first.

Protected A. A government label meaning the email contains personal information. It is about their filing, not a restriction on you. You can share your own letters with anyone you like.

ATIA. The Access to Information Act. How you ask for a copy of your own file. It used to be called FOIP.

FEDERAL WORDS

DTC. Disability Tax Credit. A federal tax credit. The form is the **T2201**. Getting approved unlocks other things.

RDSP. Registered Disability Savings Plan. A savings account with government money added. You need DTC approval first.

CDB. Canada Disability Benefit. Federal monthly money for adults. You need DTC approval first.

Child disability benefit. Extra monthly money added to the Canada Child Benefit for a child with a disability. You need DTC approval first.

Notice the pattern. Four federal things and the **DTC unlocks all of them.** If you do one piece of paperwork this year, make it the T2201.

Where this comes from: the FSCD Act and the FSCD Regulation (AR 140/2004); the PDD Services Act and its two regulations (AR 230/2013 and AR 228/2013); the FSCD policy manual; the PDD policy manual; and the alberta.ca pages for both programs. All read 28 September 2026.

Free to read, free to print, free to share. Not legal advice. If something here does not match what you were told, ask which rule they are using, and ask in writing.